



players from each State whether they have performed or not, having a national selector in the committee helps in picking the best possible 15 who have performed at the Ranji level and whom the selectors feel can move up."

Pace bench strength

Another storyline this season is India's search for reliable Test pacers. Injuries and inconsistency have left the bench exposed. Kamboj was handed a debut in England but struggled in Manchester, while Arshdeep has flirted with selection without breaking through.

For bowlers like Shami, Mukesh, Rana and Kamboj the Duleep Trophy doubles as an audition to strengthen or reclaim their spots. Selectors will also be monitoring left-arm options closely, with Khaleel hoping to push his case against Arshdeep for a

long-format role.

As the CoE prepares to host its first major tournament since opening last year, the pitch is expected to offer early assistance to fast bowlers. Those familiar with the venue, however, suggest that conditions tend to ease out as matches progress, bringing batters into the contest. Spectators, however, may be left disappointed. The CoE, located inside a residential complex on the outskirts of Bengaluru, is unlikely to allow public entry due to security concerns.

High stakes

The knockout structure leaves no room for slow starts. The mix of internationals and fringe hopefuls ensures that every match carries weight. For selectors, these five fixtures will sharpen the picture of depth across positions.

Dual call-up: Left-arm pacer Arshdeep Singh has been named in the North Zone squad for the Duleep Trophy. But with Asia Cup duty beginning September 9, he is unlikely to feature through the tournament. PTI

Former India international and Kerala coach Amay Khurasiya, who has worked closely with domestic teams, believes the switch away from a league phase benefits fast bowlers in particular.

"In the yesteryear, there were not too many games in the Ranji Trophy. But now, teams get seven matches, followed by knockouts, so that already makes the season long. If you add a round-robin Duleep on top of that, it could get hectic. Players need time to regroup and recover, especially fast bowlers. So, this move works well for them," Khurasiya says.

As the domestic calendar unfolds, the Duleep Trophy will not only showcase talent but also serve as a critical milestone in the journey of cricketers aiming for the national spotlight.

HIGHEST RUN-SCORER – WASIM JAFFER

2545

runs for West Zone and Elite Group B in 30 matches; average 55.32; best score 173 not out

HIGHEST WICKET-TAKER – NARENDRA HIRWANI

126

wickets for Central Zone and Plate Group B in 29 matches, average 34.12; best figures 7/129